

The Cruel Optimism of Staying: Understanding The Roles of Affect and Adaptation in Dating App Persistence

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Abstract

While users can choose to abandon technologies, there is a need to better understand why and how they negotiate continued use, especially when persistence can be psychologically costly. As growing evidence suggests that dating app users persist despite negative impacts to their mental health and well-being, we explore the digital dating context as a rich site to explicate the process of “staying.” Drawing on interviews with 15 dating app users, we provide an empirical account of staying that illustrates how affective and adaptive dynamics work together to sustain cyclical engagement. We find that oscillating affective patterns shape how users interpret and re-enter dating app use over time while three clusters of adaptive practices help regulate participation and manage these affective patterns. We then unpack our findings through cruel optimism, foreground hope as a key affective experience, and argue that design alone is insufficient to address the structural conditions of staying.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

online dating, dating applications, well-being, affect, engagement, persistence, cruel optimism

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1 Introduction

When online dating services debuted in the late nineties, they promised efficiency and access [29, 44]. Mobile dating applications, or dating apps, are now commonplace in many people’s digital lives as an estimated 30 percent of adults in the United States (U.S.) have

used them [36]. However, amid ubiquitous accounts of burnout and “swipe fatigue” circulating in popular media [41, 66, 69, 87], contemporary discourse has soured on their initial promise. While they still offer connection and convenience, they are increasingly associated with poor psychological outcomes. A recent poll conducted by Forbes shows that 78 percent of users report feeling burned out [69], turning to advice columns [80, 86, 88] and social media to alleviate their frustrations [85]. It is clear that the dating app experience can be taxing as dating apps companies themselves have tried to address this issue through design [47].

Growing empirical work supports this shift toward disillusionment. Psychology studies suggest that dating app users are susceptible to psychological disorders [49], loneliness and diminished relational satisfaction [81], as well as burnout and feelings of inefficacy [12, 77]. Furthermore, HCI and communication scholars have documented how dating apps can be harmful in practice by heightening emotional volatility through gamification [23], and exposing users to harms like harassment [3, 85], cyberbullying [94], and racist algorithms [2, 54, 91]. These findings reinforce broader evidence that dating app use can negatively impact mental health and well-being.

As a result, it is easy to see why many users would consider quitting dating platforms altogether. Prior work illustrates that dating app users may leave social platforms when they no longer align with their needs and goals. Leaving involves a complicated negotiation process as users grapple with the implications of leaving behind the technology itself, their practices, and a broader dating app culture [8, 17]. While the option to leave is available to anyone, reports show that user retention rates have remained relatively consistent [26], indicating that users largely choose not to leave despite a negative user experience. In this paper, we seek to understand this contradictory phenomenon: if dating apps are widely experienced as emotionally depleting, why do people continue to use them? We refer to this as *staying*—how and why people maintain a relationship to platforms over time, which we discuss in more detail in the following section.

Understanding how user affect and cognition work together to inform decision-making offers a lens for why people choose to stay [64, 75]. Affect, which encapsulates people’s mood and feelings, influences how people evaluate options, perceive risks, and prioritize outcomes. A recent simulation study demonstrates how affect fuels how users engage and disengage with dating platforms



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[20]. The simulation suggests that users' emotional states fluctuate based on unmet expectations and emotional fatigue, which drives cyclical patterns of engagement and declined emotional states over time. We build upon this work by exploring current dating app users' lived experiences and attending to their affective experiences through the research question:

RQ1: How does user affect shape people's decisions to stay on dating apps?

When people wish to remain on platforms despite an unideal experience, they lean on coping strategies to alleviate distress. For example, Birnholtz found that IM users adapt to annoying features by deleting contacts and altering their activity status indicators [13]. Wisniewski et al. further found that Facebook users cope with privacy concerns by finding external ways to manage interpersonal boundaries [92]. While these coping strategies might provide short-term relief, they may not always hold as users may decide to eventually abandon platforms [13]. Building upon previous literature on how users develop coping strategies to manage their social media use, we seek to understand how dating app users embark on a similar process through the research question:

RQ2: How do users manage their affective experiences, and what is their impact on how staying is practiced?

To address these questions, we conducted and analyzed 15 interviews with active dating app users to understand how and why they stay in systems that can trouble them. We first describe people's affective experiences, illustrating that negative affect entices leaving, but positive affect helps to justify staying. We then describe three clusters of adapting strategies that reinforce staying by helping people regulate their affective experiences: detaching from emotional impacts, calibrating engagement, and scaffolding support. As we consider wider implications for staying, we argue that Lauren Berlant's notion of cruel optimism [10] and participant's feelings of hope offers a lens to understand why staying transpires—not because dating app users are weak or irrational; rather, they may be trapped by their desire for connection. We culminate by offering both concrete suggestions and a complementary critical perspective on what design can and cannot do, contributing to growing DIS research on reducing social platform harm through design [4, 59, 70, 74].

2 Background

2.1 Dating Apps and The Commodification of Connection

Dating apps have become a common technology through which people pursue connection, increasingly occupying an important role in contemporary social and intimate life and becoming an especially valuable site to study because they mediate interactions through repeated, uncertain, and networked forms of engagement [6, 44]. While dating apps promise the potential for connection, they are neither neutral nor altruistic tools. They mediate intimacy by structuring the process of searching, matching, and interacting with potential intimate partners [29]. Dating apps, and the corporations behind them, thus yield significant power to shape people's intimate outcomes. Their design and structure afford and constrain how people engage with others, controlling whom they are visible to and

when and how they can self-present [14, 18, 28, 30]. Furthermore, dating apps allow users to narrow potential matches through built-in filters that can allow them to state or act on racial preferences, deepening bias and discrimination [54, 91].

Although dating apps claim to generate objective knowledge about how people form close relationships, scholars have suggested that their practices may reflect a profit-driven logic intended to derive value from users [1, 29]. Similarly to other mainstream social media platforms like Instagram and TikTok, these platforms are rich sites of data generation, circulation, and monetization [1]. Dating apps aggregate personal information by requiring users to create a profile that typically includes photos, their age, gender, sexual orientation, and location [89]. Profiles translate aspects of a users' identity into data points that are legible to the platform and are then cast into a digital marketplace where they can shop around for profiles with a heightened sense of selectivity [5, 37, 44].

Users then evaluate others' profiles through a binary "yes" and "no" mechanism that converts their preferences into a potential "match." Most dating apps like Tinder and Bumble follow a swipe logic—left to say no, right to say yes—that has been criticized as addictive [27]. Interaction designs like this additionally generate large volumes of data that can be sold to third parties and used internally to derive value by refining algorithms and developing pay-walled features such as limits on how many profiles a user can "like" [27, 89]. Platforms thus have the power and incentive to keep people consistently engaged.

By making people's desire for connection feel more accessible through their smartphones, dating apps have become central sites of partner seeking in contemporary society. Hobbs et al. explored whether these platforms had contributed to "liquefied love," a condition in which intimacy is increasingly marked by instability, disposability, and choice without lasting attachment [48]. Their study, however, did not find straightforward support for this idea. Instead, participants described dating apps as expanding their control, widening their networks, and increasing opportunities to find a date or life partner. As Hobbs et al. observe, users felt that dating technologies gave them greater agency in pursuing and meeting potential partners. Taken together, these findings suggest that dating apps are experienced not only as tools for helping people fulfill their desires for intimacy, but also as meaningful pathways through which desire itself is pursued and realized [48].

Berlant's concept of cruel optimism offers a way to understand how people can become dependent on dating apps as platforms hold out the promise of intimacy, validation, or connection, even though they may be detrimental to people's flourishing [10, 60]. This concept has been applied to explain why people remain attached to social arrangements that generate disillusionment or distress, including tech workers who stayed in the industry after mass layoffs [79] and marginalized Chinese dating app users who experienced anguish as app use reproduced broader cultural, gender, and class inequalities [60].

In their ethnographic study of rural Chinese migrant workers, Liu et al. show that dating apps sustain hope and attachment even as they reproduced the structural conditions that make users' desires difficult to realize, leaving them feeling stuck in circumstances they cannot meaningfully change [10, 60]. Even though they fail users, the apps continue to matter because they represent migrants'

desires for intimacy [60]. Together, this literature suggests that dating apps are not only tools for partner seeking but also affective infrastructures that can help explain why users stay in the face of disappointing or even psychologically harmful conditions. We build on this by exploring how that attachment is lived and managed in everyday use, even when the apps are disappointing or burdensome.

2.2 The Impact of Dating App Use on Well-Being

The literature we have described thus far paints a pessimistic picture of dating apps, but there are reasons to believe in their purported promise of connection. Dating apps can indeed offer meaningful mental health and well-being benefits, particularly for marginalized communities. They provide autistic users with the opportunity to meet people outside of their usual social circles with greater convenience [72]. They also allow LGBTQ+ individuals to safely explore their identities and are a key tool to connect and form relationships with others in their communities [19, 68].

However, much of the literature emphasizes harms of dating app usage. Studies across HCI, psychology, and communication studies increasingly link dating app use to negative mental health and well-being outcomes, especially for users with certain pre-disposed vulnerabilities like high rejection sensitivity [52, 94] or loneliness [24]. Users report higher levels of depression and anxiety [49], and prolonged use may exacerbate existing difficulties with initiating relationships due to fatigue [77]. Prior work on dating app burnout and fatigue capture ways in which dating app contribute to dimensions of burnout: emotional exhaustion, inefficacy, and depersonalization [77]. Others also suggest that algorithmically mediated features can intensify these negative experiences by amplifying decision fatigue and excessive swiping [12].

Furthermore, dating apps can heighten concerns over appearance and physical attractiveness, which are linked to negative self-perceptions, disordered eating, and negative mood [83]. In a study of Tinder, Sumter et al. found that dating apps can also be used as validation tools to increase self-worth, which is associated with significantly higher Tinder use [84]. Prior work has also examined negative impacts as attributed to problematic dating app use that can be measured through scales to illustrate when patterns of use becomes difficult to control or excessive [24].

It seems likely that platforms are aware of these impacts. Bumble posted an advice column on burnout, defining it as “a drained, despondent feeling” and offered suggestions on how users can manage it [80]. Hinge released a news report in 2024 describing a new feature aimed at “extinguishing dating burnout” [47] and published an annual report in 2025 that pointed out challenges users face in being emotionally vulnerable, but did not address the role the app plays [46]. These various public statements imply that their apps have emotional impacts, but shift the onus onto users to manage them.

While there are many structural factors that harm users, dating app scholarship has been similarly focused at the individual level. Privacy and security concerns are widespread, as real-time location data and personal information can be leaked and sold [61, 82]. Marginalized users must navigate additional structural harms, including algorithmic bias and sexual racism [3, 91], and grapple

with higher-stakes dilemmas of how to self-disclose sensitive information [68]. Dating app use also burdens users by offloading algorithmic sense-making and trust work, evident by studies on folk theories of opaque matchmaking algorithms [2, 51] and uncertainty reduction behaviors to authenticate potential matches [40]. They also, by design, demand constant visibility management [2, 14] and strategic self-presentation to position oneself as desirable [21].

The many burdens users are exposed to points to dating app use as a highly emotional experience, as people invest emotionally into the process of finding connection, and in turn must navigate and make sense of their emotions in the face of harm and disappointing outcomes [21, 55]. So, dating apps users face an additional challenge—engaging in emotional labor, which is the work needed to manage one’s feelings and emotional responses [35]. Similarly to the experiences of social media creators, emotional labor can become routine for dating app users who must manage their self-branding within the reputational logics of likes and matches that quantify success [5, 21]. This labor may be exacerbated for women, who often face gendered pressure to stay composed and project a positive attitude [35].

The extant work we have described thus far illustrates the affective costs of prolonged dating app use, including emotional labor and exposure to various harms. To alleviate this, users have agency to quit the technology [8], which prior work refers to as “leaving,” “departing,” and “abandoning.” The first study on this found that instant messaging (IM) users adapted their behaviors by changing their status and deleting contacts to mitigate drawbacks of the platform, but eventually abandoned the platform as it did not fully support their adaptations [13]. Relatedly, Brubaker conceptualized leaving not as a singular moment or action, but as a gradual sociotechnical process often tied to the specific place and time [17]. Leaving can thus be understood as a “relationship to a users’ goals and expectations for the app” [17]. Brubaker found that users left Grindr for a variety of reasons, notably that it was wasting their time and no longer served their particular objectives [17]. While leaving was insignificant for some, others felt a loss of potential as opting out of popular platforms can cause social disadvantages [17, 25] and stigmatization [7]. But, as we posit from dating app users’ contradictory behaviors, people do not necessarily quit after experiencing friction.

2.3 The Affective Components of "Staying"

The study of affect has been critical to HCI research seeking to support user care and well-being and offers a lens to understand why dating app users decide not to abandon the platforms [38]. User affect can be understood as a person’s emotional responses, feelings, and mood while interacting with technology [9, 53, 64]. Many have sought to quantify affect as transferable units between users and machines, but there is no consensus on how to best measure it [9, 53, 76]. Affect is crucial to people’s decision-making because it is intertwined with cognition [75]. In his influential book *Emotional Design*, Don Norman discusses how people’s emotional systems are critical information processing systems as cognition helps people understand while emotion helps people make value judgments that ultimately guide behavior [64].

If a user is angered by a feature, they may decide to disengage and abandon the platform. So, platform designers are motivated to reduce negative affect because attrition is detrimental to corporations' bottom lines [43, 65]. What can result, however, are dark patterns that encourage continued use. Dark patterns refer to manipulative design practices that exploit users' vulnerabilities; for example, adding repetitive steps to make it difficult to cancel a paid subscription [42, 63]. Platform designers can also cultivate positive affect to keep people engaged, notably through gamification features that include the previously described swipe logic, which leverages psychological patterning that can lead to compulsive use [23, 27, 67]. Given the incentive to control user engagement, it is important to question whether engagement is meaningful and desirable for users [65].

Affect, as salient components of people's decision-making and corporate business models, shows how platforms can channel users' feelings into sustained attention, interaction, and retention. In a recent study, Cela et al. built an agent-based model to test whether a plausible emotion-engagement feedback loop can generate engagement cycles [20]. Their simulations showed that repeated mismatches in agent's expectations and outcomes can produce declining emotional states that fuel cyclical patterns of engagement that may be challenging to exit from [20]. They illustrate how emotions and engagement can function as a feedback loop, creating space for empirical work to substantiate whether dating app users actually experience these dynamics in practice [20]. This work motivates our paper, which contributes an empirical account of sustained dating app use over time. We refer to how and why people decide not to abandon a platform as "staying."

Models of continued use suggest that staying is driven by rational and utilitarian decision-making. According to the Expectation Confirmation model, continued use depends on whether the technology's perceived utility is actualized [11]. Relatedly, the Engagement Model is built upon the idea that technological engagement is tied to positive appraisals of the system and continued use [78]. Other social media studies support these ideas, exploring people's motivations [84], their needs [23], and their uses and gratifications to make sense of how ongoing technology use is goal-oriented [50, 57]. These models, however, presume that people use technologies to meet various needs and leave when they no longer offer fulfillment, which may oversimplify how technology use is negotiated in practice. Building on Brubaker's sociotechnical account of leaving [17], we conceptualize staying as the inverse process: maintaining a relationship to platforms over time, even when that relationship includes temporary breaks and returns. This framing also overlaps with concepts like continued use and engagement insofar as they address users' persistence over time [11, 23, 78]. But staying directs attention not simply to whether users continue or how actively they engage, but to why the user-platform relationship persists at all and how it is sustained in practice.

Research on coping offers insight into the complicated ways staying may be sustained. Prior work shows that social media users' behaviors are driven by their emotions, and people do not necessarily leave technologies in response to negative appraisals and unmet needs. Instead, they appropriate technologies to overcome affective challenges such as annoyance with IM features [13] or stress in response to Facebook's new timeline algorithm [93]. Wisniewski et

al. created a typology of coping strategies social network site (SNS) users employ to preserve their privacy, including blocking, filtering, complying, and compromising [92]. This typology demonstrates how coping can manifest in different ways, but contribute to the same purpose: to maintain interpersonal boundaries. They also found that coping introduced added complexity and worsened people's SNS experiences, resulting in declined satisfaction and social interactions. Birnholtz's IM study also demonstrated how adapting to IM nuisances did not necessarily lead to positive outcomes as users felt that the changes they wanted to make were unsupported by the platform, which ultimately led to them abandoning it [13]. Coping then is contextual, dependent on the problems and the platforms, and not always enough to retain users. What is less understood is how dating app users in particular cope in response to unique stressors and to what extent these strategies are effective in preventing abandonment.

3 Methods

3.1 Data Collection

As illustrated in Table 1, we conducted interviews with 15 active dating app users aged 18–24 ($n=8$), 25–34 ($n=5$), and 35–44 ($n=2$). Our sample size was determined by thematic saturation, with recruitment ending once interviews no longer generated new themes or meaningful insights, which became especially apparent after coding the final interviews. Eight self-identified as "women," six as "men," and one as "non-binary." Furthermore, six identified as "White," six as "Asian," two as "Mixed Race," and one as "Black or African American." Participants were recruited via the researchers' social media accounts and university campuses in large metropolitan areas in the Midwestern and Western United States by distributing flyers across campuses, reaching out to university staff to promote the study among students, and asking participants to share the study information with others. To be eligible to participate, participants had to be at least 18 years old and have used at least one dating app within the prior seven days. Participants were compensated with a 25 U.S. dollar Amazon gift card.

The interviews, conducted over Zoom ($n=14$) and in-person ($n=1$) between June and August 2025, lasted 55 to 75 minutes. Participants were encouraged to self-report affective states and name adaptive strategies for themselves. The interview protocol focused on participant's emotional experiences of dating app use often tied to specific experiences or patterns of use, the ways they managed and coped with those feelings, and where appropriate to the flow of the interview, why they decided to stay on the apps over time. Participant's were asked questions such as, "How would you describe the emotional effect of using dating apps?", "How do you generally feel after using dating apps?", "When do you experience this emotion?", "What tools do you use to manage your dating app experiences?", "What keeps you using them?", and "What made you come back?". This often prompted follow-up questions such as "How did that make you feel?", "What impact did that have?", and "How would you describe that?". The goal of this study is not to measure the intensity of affect or provide a taxonomy of affective states and adaptive practices, but rather to explore how these components impact how staying is negotiated and practiced in the dating app context.

Prior to the interviews, the researchers obtained informed consent from the participants for their involvement in the study and for audio recording. After the interviews were completed, the recordings were transcribed using Otter.Ai. To protect participants' privacy, the researchers then removed identifiable information such as cities, from the transcripts. Participants were also assigned pseudonyms during transcription that broadly reflected their ethnic and cultural backgrounds to preserve this aspect of identity without compromising anonymity.

3.2 Data Analysis

The data analysis process was informed by Braun and Clarke's conceptualization of reflexive thematic analysis (RTA), which is described as a recursive process [15, 16]. First, three of the authors read through the transcripts to familiarize themselves with the data, created memos of initial themes, and discussed observations. The next step involved coding the transcripts using the Dedoose software, during which the same authors independently developed initial codes related to the research questions. These early codes pertained to participants' general dating app use, feelings, and coping strategies. In this stage, the researchers used the feelings wheel developed by psychologist Gloria Wilcox as a tool to help ground discussions [90]. This tool helped create a common language to talk about the feelings observed in the data. However, it did not limit interpretations of what "counts" as a feeling and created space to critique this taxonomy for its limitations and rigid categorization of emotional valence [90]. The process of understanding participants' affective experiences was more deductive as the researchers used the feelings wheel as a guide. The process of identifying people's adaptive practices were more inductive as quotes like "I started to see things as out of my control" demanded more interpretation.

These codes were refined and collapsed over multiple rounds of coding, re-coding, and meeting to resolve uncertainties and misalignment. This recursive process resulted in a set of codes the authors agreed upon to allow for more systematic and consistent coding. After coding was completed, the codes were categorized into higher-level themes. For example "not taking things seriously," "re-framing the problem," and "coping with humor" were combined into "detaching from emotional impact."

Our interpretation of participant's affective experiences with dating apps is shaped by our positions as researchers of communication technologies and our personal experiences interacting with these platforms. Most members of the research team have direct experience with both the positive and negative aspects of dating app use, while others are familiar with these dynamics through the experiences of friends, colleagues, and broader social worlds. As a result, we approach participant's accounts not as a matter of individual failure but as shaped by the social, technical, and structural conditions of dating apps. To ensure that our own biases were not superseding participant's experiences, we frequently discussed our own reactions to ensure that interpretations were tied to data as opposed to our own emotional responses.

3.3 Limitations

While we believe our work contributes important nuance to our understanding of how dating app users negotiate whether to remain

in platforms, our results should be interpreted in light of several limitations. Per our conceptualization of "staying," this study focused on the experiences of current dating app users. While we believe this focus helped provide a rich account of staying, it may be beneficial to include the experiences of people who had previously "stayed" but eventually abandoned dating apps for good. While our sample was diverse in terms of sexual orientation, most participants identified as "Asian" (40%) and White (40%) and aged 18-24 (53.33%) and 25-34 (33.33%). We know that marginalized groups, and possibly other age groups may face unique challenges in this context, and the stakes for participation may be different.

During the interviews, participants also disclosed emotions often tied to insecurities and mental health and many reflected on their experience with intensity and passion. While we tried to facilitate a safe space that encouraged vulnerability and a balanced reflection, we cannot eliminate the possibility that participants responded in ways that they thought would be viewed favorably.

4 Findings

It was apparent in our findings that deciding to stay was not a simple or irrational decision but rather a nuanced negotiation of how dating apps made them feel and how they justified enduring negative experiences. Participants, who had been using dating apps for as short as five months to as long as ten years, described feeling conflicting desires to leave or abandon dating apps. Our analysis illustrates that people stay in dating apps because they feel drawn in by positive affect; even when their experiences felt suboptimal, they found various ways improve and manage it.

In 4.1, we detail how participant's affective states were intertwined with staying, wanting to leave when their experiences felt negative but pulled in by positive feelings like validation and hope. In 4.2 we describe participants' adaptive practices that helped them manage these affective patterns and reinforced staying. Participants' empirical accounts support Cela et al.'s simulation study that posits a feedback loop between affect and engagement. Our findings add nuance into how this dynamic plays out in practice, and illustrates how this loop is reinforced and sustained by additional adaptive work [20].

4.1 Affective Dynamics of Staying

Our participants frequently used language like "upswings and downswings" or "a cycle" to describe how their feelings fluctuated over time. As Natalie describes: "it was like, initial excitement, and then I got stressed, and then I was starting to get excited again." For many participants, their experiences were marked by persistent and recurrent negative affect—feeling overwhelmed, frustrated, fatigued, and anxious. Yet these feelings were often punctuated by moments of positive affect—like feeling validated and hopeful.

In this section, we address **RQ1: How does user affect shape people's decisions to stay on dating apps?** Through our analysis, we found that participants experienced oscillations between negative and positive affect. While negative affect was recurrent and pushed participants into wanting to leave, feelings of validation and hope pulled people back in by motivating and justifying their decisions to stay.

Pseudonym	Gender	Race/Ethnicity	Age	Sexual Orientation	Platforms Used
Levi	Man	White	25–34	Homosexual/gay/lesbian	Hinge, Feeld, Grindr
Jasmine	Woman	Mixed race	18–24	Homosexual/gay/lesbian	Hinge, Tinder, Bumble, HER
Felix	Man	Mixed race	18–24	Homosexual/gay/lesbian	Grindr, Hinge, Tinder
James	Man	White	18–24	Homosexual/gay/lesbian	Hinge, Tinder
Amelia	Woman	Black or African American	35–44	Bisexual	Hinge, Tinder, Bumble, Coffee Meets Bagel, HER
Jackie	Non-binary	Asian	18–24	Homosexual/gay/lesbian	Hinge, Tinder, Bumble
Amir	Man	Asian	25–34	Homosexual/gay/lesbian	Hinge, Tinder, Raya, Grindr, Scruff
Megan	Woman	White	18–24	Bisexual	Hinge
Kevin	Man	Asian	25–34	Heterosexual	Hinge
Eleanor	Woman	White	35–44	Heterosexual	Hinge, Tinder, Bumble, The League, Coffee Meets Bagel, eHarmony
Mina	Woman	Asian	18–24	Heterosexual	Hinge
Varun	Man	Asian	25–34	Heterosexual	Hinge
Emme	Woman	White	18–24	Bisexual	Hinge
Anya	Woman	Asian	25–34	Heterosexual	Hinge, Bumble
Natalie	Woman	White	18–24	Homosexual/gay/lesbian	Hinge

Table 1: Participant demographics and dating app use.

4.1.1 Persistent and Recurrent Negative Affect. For many, negative affect was the predominant condition they felt themselves in, characterized by feeling overwhelmed, frustrated, fatigued, and anxious.

Participants described negative affect as detrimental to their well-being and attributed it to a variety of causes. Many described using dating apps as “work” or “a grind” that requires “energy” and “effort.” Swiping, curating profiles, crafting messages, and sustaining conversations with matches demanded significant labor as participants had to monitor their self-presentation and grapple with undesirable outcomes.

Several participants described this work as unique compared to other social media. Megan explained that dating apps require more effort because “you don’t have preexisting relationships” and creates a draining “game of comparison” where you evaluate your attractiveness relative to others. Levi described feeling overwhelmed because, compared to Instagram and LinkedIn, dating apps require a higher “level of requisite engagement” and create the “impossible task to capture everything in a profile.” This is akin to hidden labor of social media influencers, which happens behind profiles, comes with significant emotional expenditure, and is often unrewarded [32, 33].

The pressure of what multiple participants called “putting yourself out there” led to common cause of fear and anxiety—being judged by others. As Emme explained:

Hinge puts you in a vulnerable position where people can see you and perceive you and I think where that anxiety stems from is judgment. I’m very scared of how people perceive me... when I was on campus, I would get screenshots of people’s profiles sent to our group chats and people would judge them and say

things about them, so my fear is people are going to judge me and say things about me.

Emme surfaced how dating apps are risky by design, as profiles are broadcast to an unknown and judgmental audience that can leak her information outside the apps. Several participants similarly attributed negative affect to the structure of dating apps. Jackie described feeling frustrated because they struggled with forming deep connections in “the context of this digital world” and that dating app profiles encourage overthinking.

Negative affect was also tied to perceived failure to produce satisfying interactions or receive likes, which supports prior work on how people’s perceived lack of success in attracting partners is linked to increased loneliness and decreased life satisfaction [81]. But internalizing these outcomes further exacerbated negative feelings.

Participants like Anya described how, in the first few years of using dating apps, they were her sole source of finding potential partners. Her dependency on the apps, however, lead her to attribute failure to her own shortcomings, believing that “if you’re single, it’s your fault... you’re not trying hard enough.” This mindset was not only detrimental to her well-being but also forced her into a period of intense engagement with the goal of initiating three to four dates a week. Anya’s negative affect at first pushed her to swipe more, but this push for “quantity over quality” ultimately led her to burn out. While Anya tried to diversify her options after burning out, she speculated that dating offline feels challenging because people feel hesitant to approach and get rejected by someone in person, leading them to rely on dating apps as a lower-risk alternative.

After periods of prolonged negative affect, many participants also described taking breaks. But their negative experiences were not enough to abandon dating apps entirely. Eleanor, who had been

using dating apps for over a decade, felt tempted to quit but also simultaneously compelled to stay.

[Dating app use] highly affects my mental health...and yet I feel trapped. It's such a superficial experience and I am so burned out. I've been doing this so long, and it's depressing. I do want to meet a lifetime partner, right? I want to get married and all of this but I feel like quitting. I've gone through times where I've had at least six apps on my phone at a given time. Then I'm like, okay, I'm going to reduce it to two. And that doesn't help. So then I think I'm going to quit it for a while. But then it's like, how else do you meet people? As people are getting married and serious about relationships later in life, and we work really long and hard hours, how else do you meet people?

After repeated attempts to scale back her use, Eleanor felt drawn back because of the perceived lack of dating alternatives, making her feel stuck even though she felt burned out and depressed. While a few participants expressed interest in pursuing non-digital means of connection, several echoed this tension that they wanted to leave but dating apps felt like the obligatory path to connection in contemporary dating culture.

Jasmine added that while she would like seek offline alternatives to dating apps, doing so feels especially challenging for LGBTQ+ people, as she perceives these "third spaces" to be limited and difficult to enter. Felix also expressed that dating apps offer an easier route to connection, believing that "other avenues of meeting people can feel stressful" and meeting someone in the physical world "feels like a foreign concept."

Across these accounts, negative affect enticed leaving and made staying feel difficult. But as Eleanor foreshadows, participants sought to manage the negativity they experienced.

4.1.2 Brief and Infrequent Positive Affect. Many participants described fleeting feelings of fun and enjoyment. Natalie, for example, described her early Hinge use as fun. But as her anxiety over her self-presentation accumulated, she described her current use as ambivalent, "like you're playing a stressful game...it's fun but stressful."

For multiple participants, positive affect was closely tied to feeling validation, which is described as feeling approved and accepted by others. Dating apps made validation tangible through likes and responses. This feedback, as Emme described, felt good "when someone responds to one of your pictures or responses...it's like, oh, someone thinks I'm funny, wow I'm interesting." Amir similarly described how receiving likes and compliments enticed him to re-download Grindr after taking breaks, but these feelings were often short-lived:

I've deleted Grindr when I'm like "this is not serving me at all, like, I hate this." That's like an on and off cycle where I had it and then I delete it and then I had it, and I delete it, and I think I re-download it because I'm seeking validation...One day, I'll send witty, fun messages to a million people and have fun with it. And then the next day, I'm like, I don't want to respond to all these people and I don't have the

time. So it's this push and pull, which kind of makes it hard.

Amir illustrated how positive and negative affect oscillate—he steps away when negative affect escalates, returns to seek validation, but is at once overcome with the same negative affect that makes him want to step away again. The resulting "push-pull" dynamic made it difficult for him to abandon dating apps entirely.

Multiple participants described hope as an anchor to persist through negative experiences. Amelia, who had been dependent on dating apps for nearly a decade as "the only way to meet people nowadays," described a period where she was deleting and re-downloading dating apps at least once a month because they negatively impacted her mental health. Her sense of hope was mapped onto these cycles, deleting the apps when her "hope is at the very least," but re-downloading the apps when, for example, she found out her friend successfully met a boyfriend on Hinge. While Amelia's hope wavered, it kept her committed to seeking connection, believing that "there's no way I'm not gonna find my person...I have to believe that."

Jackie similarly said that their belief that "there's someone out there for you" is "enough to keep me coming back because what if this time, something actually happens." Despite that Jackie found it hard to form connections virtually and described dating apps as not a great place for "hopeless romantics" like them, Jackie continued to "hold out hope for the possibility that someone will come along." Jackie's "what if this time" mentality helped them justify staying in an environment that they recognized as misaligned.

While negative experiences could hamper hope, Felix, who had successfully made meaningful friendships through dating apps, described how past positive experiences strengthened his hope in finding a romantic partner:

Knowing that genuine connection of different kinds is possible, it does give me some element of hope, a reason to still use them...I think the element of oh it is possible, the hope aspect, which is hard to hold onto at times, is the overarching factor of it all. I don't think I would be using it if I didn't think there was some potential.

Hope was seldom steady. Several participants like Kevin, described his hope as precarious, dropping during "dry spells" of not receiving or sending any likes and spiking around moments of possibility such as seeing a compatible profile. He further described how hope can be designed into Hinge, which provides users with curated suggestions of who they are most "compatible" with. For Kevin, feeling hopeful and excited about a profile are why he "puts up with the swiping."

While Eleanor earlier described feeling trapped because of a lack of alternatives, a few participants like Levi and Amir described feeling trapped by hope. Amir discussed how dating apps create the illusion of endless profiles, leading to a "never-ending cycle of hoping there's someone better." Levi suspected that platforms can manufacture hope by releasing a "slow drip" that gives him "enough feelings of success of hope" to make leaving difficult. Eleanor similarly questioned dating app companies' design motives, believing that "they want to keep you on there," describing premium features that require users to pay for higher quality matches.

Positive affect, although short-lived and sometimes met with skepticism, operated as an affective pull, helping to motivate and justify staying despite negative experiences. Megan's response is telling of why she thinks it is worth it to endure negative dating app experiences:

It's sort of like asking if dating someone you ended up breaking up with was worth it. Even if there's probably a negative outcome, you've got to risk it to meet people to have those good experiences... the results are more important than the process of using the app... having a long-term partner is good for your mental health.

4.2 Reinforcing Staying Through Adaptive Work

Our participants described regulating the affective patterns described in the prior section. As Amelia illustrates: "I was in such a bad mood that it kind of kicked me into thinking about how to take care of myself. I was like, I can't be on the apps like this..." While many participants described still grappling with the mental health and well-being impacts of dating app use, they took charge through self-care. Some entered the interview aware they had actively been working to manage these negative impacts, while others only came to the realization they were during the interview.

In this section, we address **RQ2: How do users manage their affective experiences, and what is their impact on how staying is practiced?** We found that participants adapted in various ways to manage the emotional turbulence: detaching from emotional impacts, calibrating engagement, and scaffolding support. Some of these strategies were directly supported by the platforms, such as pausing profiles, while others were sought external to the platforms. Nevertheless, participant's coping strategies were effective in preventing abandonment by helping users manage and alleviate negative affect and even cultivate positive affect.

4.2.1 Detaching from Emotional Impacts. One set of practices encompasses how participants did not fully withdraw emotionally, but instead adjusted their interpretations and expectations so that negative experiences felt lighter and less self-defining. We refer to this as detaching from emotional impacts.

For some, detaching necessitated shifting blame away from themselves and not internalizing poor outcomes and experiences. Eleanor, who described feeling "like a baseball card being traded" learned to re-direct blame toward the platforms by reminding herself that no person can reasonably "fit on a two dimensional screen." Multiple participants described leveraging professional mental health support to facilitate this. For Jasmine, learning to detach required time, vulnerability, and introspection guided by her therapist:

In my head, I have a dating profile, and nobody is swiping back. I'm imagining that 100 people are rejecting me. And so in my therapy session, my therapist will be like, imagine that scenario and then tell me what you're thinking and feeling after. And then I'm able to say, like oh, it comes from a fear of not being able to be loved... Then my therapist is able to say this

isn't your fault, this is a common, universal, human emotion of fear. That was able to quell a lot of my fear about being on dating apps initially, and now I'm more just frustrated with the algorithm rather than myself.

Many participants described adopting a lighter or as Amelia called an "unserious" approach to using dating apps, caring less not because their desire for connection mattered less, but because they learned to not let the apps impact them as much. For others, re-framing interactions as less serious helped them detach. Natalie, for example, learned to view rejection as interactions with "just a random person that you met online... it's not that deep." Anya, who burned out after a period of high-intensity usage to maximize outcomes, similarly learned to accept dating app outcomes as "out of her control" and attributed to "luck and timing."

Anya also described a related strategy—coping with humor:

We try to find the humor in it because otherwise it's just so sad... you need to have some distance from the situation."

Finding humor and absurdity in bad experiences also helped, as Anya said, create "distance" from negativity. Numerous participants described turning bad dating app moments into funny stories they could swap with friends, laugh about, and move past. Humor, in addition to shifting blame and re-framing problems, functioned as an affective buffer that helped people metabolize and alleviate the weight of their negative experiences, and as an added bonus, introduced a touch of joy and fun.

By perceiving dating app experiences as "unserious," "not that deep," "out of my control," or "absurd," participants distanced themselves from negative affect, which enabled staying by making their affective experiences feel less intense.

4.2.2 Calibrating Engagement. Many participants also treated their dating app use as something to dose or bound. In practice, many participants set boundaries by limiting when and how much they participated, often by changing the technical environment like pausing their profile. We refer to these practices as calibrated engagement.

Numerous participants described taking breaks as intentional, strategic disengagement to reset emotions and energy. Breaks often followed periods of heightened frustration or fatigue, creating space to reset attention and reduce rumination. In line with Brubaker's work on leaving [17], breaks manifested through various technical actions, whether by deleting their accounts or removing the apps from their phones. Jasmine, for example, deliberated opted to delete her entire account, so that all previous matches and conversations disappeared making it "feel new" and like "starting from scratch" when she inevitably returned.

In this sense, leaving served as a coping strategy that enabled staying, preventing negative affect from accumulating and making impending return feel possible. Felix, however, who used to take breaks every couple of weeks, reflected on the effectiveness of break-taking as a strategy that only tricked him into feeling like it was helpful.

Now every I'd say twice a year, I kind of hit this, oh, I need to take a break, take a little bit of time off... I

did that for years, and would delete it like, every two weeks. I think it was more just trying to trick my brain into thinking I was, like, doing something good for myself.

After questioning if breaks were “truly recharging,” he later described that learning to be present in other spaces was truly what helped keep his brain “in check” so that dating apps were not constantly in the back of his mind.

Many participants also described setting smaller boundaries that disciplined everyday use: checking the apps less often, pausing their profiles to reduce the number of matches they had to manage, and limiting the time they spent on specific app activities. Mina, who felt burned out after managing many matches, described pausing her profile at the end of each Hinge session so that she could only receive likes when she had the app open. This strategically reduced the quantity of people who could see her profile and ultimately the time she had to spend initiating conversations with suitors, which she found overwhelming and stressful.

Participants also calibrated engagement by creating rules and heuristics that made swiping and messaging feel more manageable. Kevin developed a rule where he could only message one match at a time to alleviate decision fatigue from managing simultaneous matches. Jasmine similarly used a “5-10 second scroll” per profile rule to avoid ruminating during swiping sessions. Eleanor created a checklist of questions she would ask herself when assessing a profile to make easier decisions:

Is there at least one picture of him that looks professional in his profile? Does he talk about his family?
Does he talk about his faith at all? Is there at least one picture that looks like you would have it on LinkedIn?

In these accounts, participants set engagement boundaries and developed heuristics that helped mitigate feeling overwhelmed, fatigued, and stressed.

4.2.3 Scaffolding Support. Many participants added layers of support as they navigated dating app use: grounding through real life connections, seeking advice, and commiserating with others. These strategies helped to encourage people to keep going and at times provided confidence and relief. We refer to these practices as scaffolding support.

When asked what is most helpful in response to negative affect, several participants described the idea of “just being with my people.” Amir captured this protective function, describing seeking out time with friends to feel “rooted and grounded in my community” so that negative app experiences no longer defined him. Levi similarly described “feeling in community with other people” as an important tool to get through his dating app experience. Established, in-real-life connections helped ground people, which was important as dating app use could trigger insecurity about people’s capacity for connection and their sense of self.

Participants also frequently recruited others—friends, sisters, therapists, and increasingly social media forums and chatbots to manage their affective experiences. Rather than treating dating apps as an individual burden, participants made it a shared problem of sense-making and support, with a few participants like Mina and

Anya describing chatbots like ChatGPT as a low-cost way to get support without burdening other people with their problems.

Talking to others about dating app experiences also helped with countering the isolating and self-referential tendencies of app use. As Jackie put it, it can be easy to “lose yourself in the apps” or become “delusional,” and feels that it is important to have “someone to call you out.”

Another strategy, advice-seeking, offered instrumental support. Turning to friends for concrete suggestions made participation feel more manageable and less taxing. Participants described asking friends which photos to use, how their prompts read, or what message to send. Varun described turning his app use into a fun social activity where friends provided “tangible action items” and even swiped with him:

Talking to your friends about it is super fun. I sometimes show my profile to my friends and they give me good recommendations. Right now my Hinge profile is the updated version with a couple of recs I received from some of my friends. They’re like, “No, this picture is not good. You gotta show more people on your photos, it cannot be just you.”

Across these accounts, trusted advice from others functioned as scaffold, making them feel more confident and reduced the sense that participants had to manage their experiences alone.

Another related strategy, commiseration, helped with emotional regulation. As Levi, put it, sharing stories with fellow dating app users provided a sense of relief as it made him realize “that a lot of the things that are coming up for me are not necessarily unique to me.” Amelia similarly described the value of talking to others as creating “camaraderie” that “it’s not just me...it’s bad for everybody.” Eleanor detailed how talking to friends is cathartic and encouraging:

I need to just vent my frustration. It’s like a sounding board. And then also I need encouragement, because being on there makes me feel more alone. So I need my friends to kind of be like, keep going.

While these scaffolding strategies may be unsurprising, they are important in understanding how staying happens. Participants build an affective support infrastructure to navigate the emotionally volatile dating app experience. Scaffolding helped people manage overcome low moments, re-build confidence, and encourage them to “keep going.” Due to this added supportive layer around app use, staying felt and was made more possible.

5 Discussion

We began with the question of how and why people stay in dating app systems that are often negatively experienced and detrimental to their mental health and well-being. Participant’s accounts indicate that positive affect like hope and validation can justify this contradictory behavior, which supports and adds nuance to prior work suggesting that engagement and affect operate as a feedback loop [20]. But staying is not driven solely by affective dynamics as our findings also suggest that people’s adaptive practices may play a key role in sustaining staying by preventing negative affect from intensifying. While our findings primarily foreground people’s decision-making and experiences at an individual-level, they also point to structural forces that shape the staying process,

including the desire for love and intimacy, the design of apps, and the contemporary dating landscape.

In this discussion, we take a wider perspective on why staying happens, drawing from prior HCI research that calls for situating design and practice within broader ecologies [45, 56, 62]. We first unpack our findings through the lens of cruel optimism, which helps to explain users' accounts of staying not simply as a contradictory phenomenon but as an attachment constrained by institutions. We then focus on our findings around hope as the lived affect through which that attachment is sustained, showing that hope itself can be shaped by platform design and market logics. Since our discussion points to the role of larger platform- and institutional-level forces, we propose design implications for better supporting users, clarify the limits of design's role, and suggest that structural interventions are needed in addition to design.

5.1 Cruel Optimism as an Interpretive Lens

Our participants described cycles of engagement, withdrawal, and return, often prompted by oscillating affective experiences and reinforced by various adaptive strategies. Staying then, can be understood as a process of affective management and renegotiation, through which users responded to how dating apps made them feel, and made their ongoing relationship with these platforms feel healthier and survivable. Cruel optimism offers a framework to understand why people keep returning to and renegotiating their relationships with dating apps despite persistent and recurrent negative experiences. The premise of cruel optimism is that people develop deep affective attachments to objects of desire, such as love and intimacy, which are entangled with conventional institutions like monogamy, marriage, and in this case, dating apps [10, 29]. Due to these attachments, people learn to "inhabit fantasy" by emotionally investing and developing unconscious processes to attain these desires [10, 29]. Attachments, however, can become cruel when they lead people to stay in conditions harmful to their flourishing in pursuit of attaining their desired objects [10].

Cruel optimism can help explain our participants' contradictory behaviors, such as Eleanor, who described how her desire "to meet a lifetime partner" is in tension with feelings of depression and burn out. Rather than seeing users like Eleanor as weak or irrational, Eleanor may be trapped in a cruelly optimistic relationship with dating apps, as the object of desire (a long-term connection) is entangled with the object that organizes access to it (the app). Her attachment then is not necessarily to the apps, but what the apps stand in for: a possible route to establishing a connection. For Eleanor, her desire becomes cruel as using dating apps deteriorates her mental health. She wants to quit because she feels depressed and burned out, but stays because she feels compelled to stay on the apps as they seem to be the only viable route to connection in today's world.

Cruel optimism also offers a lens for understanding the role of participants' adaptive practices in the staying process. According to Berlant, those embroiled in relations of cruel optimism contend with a few options. While people can revolt or exit, people more often "tread water in the impasse," finding ways to endure through cruelty as their desires remain unresolved [10, 60]. The adaptive work our participants engaged in—seeking social support from friends, using

the apps less often, managing their emotions—illustrates what may be the reality of staying afloat in a dating ecosystem increasingly organized through platform logics [1, 5, 29, 89]. Participants were not only coping with the apps they were using, but their accounts demonstrate a reckoning with the broader challenge of seeking connection beyond them in contemporary dating society, which may feel especially difficult for LGBTQ+ people.

Our findings echo prior work that using dating apps requires significant emotional labor [5, 21] as users navigate the apps and harmful experiences, and develop strategies to manage their emotions in response. We build on this, suggesting that in staying, users must also manage their own relationships with dating apps to stay afloat, by detaching, calibrating, and scaffolding. While prior work refers to this as coping [92, 93] and adapting [13], this additional layer of labor may be better understood here as *attachment work*. This refers to the additional effort needed to "tread water" to keep the attachment alive without being fully consumed by the affective costs.

So, people's decision to stay on dating apps despite feeling that they are bad for their well-being may appear contradictory and irrational. But understood through cruel optimism, staying is less paradoxical. As dominant institutions for organizing access to love and connection in contemporary society, dating apps mediate these deeply held desires that are not easily relinquished, helping explain why users remain even under adverse conditions. Cruel optimism helps to explain staying as a form of attachment; turning to hope allows us to examine how attachments are sustained in practice and can be cultivated through platform design and market logics.

5.2 Hope as Sociotechnical

From a cruel optimism perspective, hope is the lived affect through which attachment is sustained, and for that reason is central to staying. As Liu et al. show in their study of Chinese migrant dating app users, hope does not necessarily reflect positive outcomes. Rather, it expresses continued attachment to the promise of intimacy even when that promise is repeatedly thwarted [60]. Our findings similarly show that hope functioned as an anchor that sustained participant's relationship to dating apps through frustration, exhaustion, and disappointment. Felix, for example, described hope as what kept him oriented toward the possibility of connection despite recurring negative experiences, while Jackie described hope bound up with their belief in fate.

Our data further suggest that hope was precarious, as participants often had to maintain it through ongoing interpretive and emotional work by talking to friends and managing disappointment. Staying then, was also sustained by the labor of preserving hope in the face of uncertainty and negative outcomes. This parallels with on the hidden "hope labor" of social media creators who desire eventual payoff but continuously engage in emotional and interpretive repair in response to the uncertainties of opaque algorithmic systems [32–34].

Other participant accounts suggest that hope is not merely an internal state, but is also shaped through platform design. Kevin's account demonstrates how hope is tied to both feelings of inadequacy, when he does not receive likes, and to design features, such as Hinge's compatibility signals that cultivate it. Hope, then, may

be better understood as a sociotechnical condition that is shaped by users' unique lived experiences and platforms' features. This idea of sociotechnical hope resonates with growing HCI literature that situates hope as an end goal in design and a practice through which people survive uncertainty in everyday life [58, 71, 73], and as something that "grows and is maintained through ongoing interactions with the world" [71].

If hope is shaped in part by platform design, platforms should not be treated as neutral intermediaries but as institutions that can influence how hope is sustained and experienced [1, 29, 44]. As dating app platforms organize access to love and intimacy, they deserve critical scrutiny in relation to how sustain users' attachments may serve their interests. Participant's accounts of hope point to a tension: while hope sustains staying, it can also be shaped by designs that align less with users' desires for eventual connection and exit than with platforms' interest in prolonged use [5]. Gamified features such as swiping mechanisms found on many dating apps make this tension visible, as they are designed to sustain repeated engagement through which platforms may derive value through data collection [1, 23, 29]. In this sense, hope is not only central to staying, but can also become a resource that platforms can help sustain and benefit from.

We do not claim that platforms intentionally engineer hope, whether by "trapping" users through giving the illusion of endless profiles, as Amir suggested, or by providing a "slow drip" of matches that produces just enough sensations of success to sustain use, as Levi speculated. However, consistent with prior work showing that dating apps leverage users' psychological vulnerabilities to facilitate engagement [23, 27, 67], our findings suggest that hope itself warrants closer scrutiny as a vulnerability that may be exploited through platform design, including as a dark pattern mechanism [42]. We do not suggest that hope is inherently problematic. Rather, participants' accounts show that hope is not merely an individual feeling, but one shaped by platform design and market logics. This raises important questions about how platforms may cultivate, amplify, or prolong hope in ways that sustain staying and reinforce cruel optimism. For HCI and design, this means recognizing that hope can become extractive.

5.3 Design Implications and Beyond

In considering how we might meaningfully change users' experiences, we begin by asking how platforms might better support those who choose to stay. The question for design, then, is how the staying process might be made more livable and survivable. At the same time, because our discussion shows how hope and attachment can themselves be cultivated through platform design, design must also be attentive to how it may intensify cruel optimism and prolong staying in ways that serve platform interests. For this reason, we argue that design must also be paired with broader structural intervention, specifically efforts to build critical literacy around how dating apps shape desire, hope, and staying. Although our findings are based on a sample of 15 dating app users and should not be assumed to apply uniformly across all populations, they nonetheless point to several directions for action and future work.

One opportunity for design is to target the sources of negative affect. Prior work demonstrates that using dating apps demands

substantial time, effort, and energy [21, 77], and our study identified salient forms of negative affect, including anxiety, frustration, and overwhelm. Participant's accounts suggest that reducing these burdens may require designing for more manageable forms of participation. For instance, design can help users focus on fewer but more promising connections. Hinge's "Your Turn Limits" feature, which restricts how many conversations users can leave without replying, offers one example of this approach [47]. Platforms could also help participants identify how dating apps make them feel by offering check-in tools to help users notice patterns in their emotional states. Not all harms, however, are equally addressable through design. While design can reduce certain burdens, other forms of negative affect we identified, for example exposure to judgment and failure to receive likes, may be more difficult to address through design alone because they emerge through the social dynamics of app use.

Design can also support users' attachment work by bolstering the adaptive practices they employ to remain afloat. Many participants described altering their patterns of use or finding ways to engage on their own terms. Platforms could better support intentional pauses, smoother transitions in and out of app use, and tools that help users track their engagement over time. Prior work also points the value of design in scaffolding reflection and social support around app use [39]. Participants often managed difficult experiences by stepping back, making sense of what was happening by talking to trusted others. Platforms might also offer lightweight reflective tools, such as journaling or note features to help users process and recall experiences. Instead of treating adaptive work as an individual burden, design can play a role in supporting the practices users already rely on. These interventions, however, may be more helpful in managing the burdens of "treading water" rather than addressing the structural conditions that make staying feel compelling. Although platforms can offer limited forms of care, they cannot replace the care participants described receiving from friends and therapists outside the apps.

Since staying emerges within people's broader structural worlds—shaped by their expectations about and hopes for love and intimacy as well as by platforms and commodification—addressing it requires interventions that engage these broader conditions. Returning to Berlant, people caught in cruel optimism can remain stuck or they attempt to revolt or exit. Yet our findings, alongside prior work, suggest that disengaging from technological systems can carry significant costs, as doing so may mean giving up access to potential partners [17]. Our participants similarly described dating opportunities outside of apps as daunting or inaccessible. From this perspective, the challenge may not be how to encourage exit or revolt, but how to help users better understand the conditions that make staying feel necessary in the first place. Design can make dating app use feel less harmful and more bearable, but may be limited because staying is shaped not only by platform features, but by broader social, economic, and cultural conditions that cannot be addressed through design alone [31].

Existing frameworks of social media literacy offer a useful direction. Cho et al. argue that literacy requires understanding the self, the medium, and the reality that emerges through people's interactions [22]. They also emphasize the competencies of analysis, evaluation, and contribution, suggesting that literacy involves not

only understanding platform environments but also developing the skills to critically engage with them [22]. When applied to dating apps, this suggests that interventions should help users better understand their own hopeful attachments to apps, the platform logics that shape dating culture, and the realities of love and intimacy institutions produce that make dating apps feel compelling. It is possible that literacy may open up space for users to imagine alternative ways of pursuing intimacy and connection. Future work can examine how such competencies might be cultivated in the dating app context, and how responsibility for that work might be distributed across platform designers, researchers, educators, and policy actors.

Taken together, our discussion positions staying as a process sustained through hope, attachment, and adaptive practices within broader structural conditions. Addressing staying requires interventions aimed not only at reducing individual burdens through design, but also at fostering users' critical understanding of the broader platform and institutional realities shaping their engagement—an aim that design alone cannot fully achieve.

5.4 Future Work

Our participants used a variety of apps, notably Hinge, Tinder, Grindr, and Bumble. It could be worthwhile for future work to examine whether similar or divergent patterns emerge across different dating apps, which vary in their design and target demographic. Additionally, our data analysis relied on semi-structured interviews, where participants retroactively reflected on their past experiences. While the interviews provided time and space for participants to reflect deeply on their experiences, other in-situ and longitudinal methods, like diary studies or experience sampling, could be useful to capture more in-the-moment affective states and adaptation and could be used to to examine whether similar or divergent patterns emerge across different dating apps and different durations of use.

Although our empirical claims are limited to this setting, our conceptualization may offer a useful bridge to adjacent scholarship. Future work could extend the concept of staying beyond dating apps by examining its relevance to adjacent scholarship on hope labor, influencer culture, and dark patterns, particularly as a way of understanding how ongoing engagement is sustained not only through design mechanisms, but also through aspiration, attachment, and the promise of future rewards. There is also opportunity for future work to more systematically disentangle the sources of negative affect and other difficult experiences associated with dating apps, distinguishing those that stem from broader dating practices and those produced or exacerbated by platforms themselves. Such work could extend the analysis presented by more clearly locating points of responsibility and points of intervention.

6 Conclusion

The negative mental health and well-being implications of dating apps necessitates an understanding of why people may choose to use technologies that can simultaneously allow them to meet their needs, and cause significant negative user affect. Our results highlight how people decision to stay in systems are neither simple nor straightforward. They must negotiate competing feelings and

develop ways to manage their emotionally volatile dating app experiences. By exploring this process of staying, we demonstrate the importance of understanding the structural conditions that reinforce staying in the dating app context and create space for further discussion about how to best address this in HCI through design and beyond.

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